manual of recipes, formulation and prescriptions. *Hastyayurveda* or the veterinary science authored by Palakapya attests to the advances made in medical science during the Gupta period.

7.7 Decline of the Gupta Empire

The last recognised king of the Gupta line was Vishnugupta who reigned from 540 to 550 CE. Internal fighting and dissensions among the royal family led to its collapse. During the reign of a Gupta king, Budhagupta, the Vakataka ruler Narendrasena of western Deccan, attacked Malwa, Mekala and Kosala. Later on, another Vakataka king Harishena conquered Malwa and Gujarat from the Guptas. During Skanda Gupta's reign, the grandson of Chandragupta II, the Huns invaded northwest India. He was successful in repulsing the Huns, but consequently his empire was drained of financial resources. In the sixth century CE, the Huns occupied Malwa, Gujarat, Punjab and Gandhara. As the Hun invasion weakened the Gupta hold in the country, independent rulers emerged all over the north like Yasodharman of Malwa, the Maukharis of Uttar Pradesh, the Maitrakas in Saurashtra and others in Bengal. In time, the Gupta Empire came to be restricted to only Magadha. They did not focus on empire building and military conquests. So, weak rulers along with incessant invasions from foreign as well as native rulers caused the decline of the Gupta Empire. By the beginning of the sixth century, the empire had disintegrated and was ruled by many regional chieftains.

Feudalism : The social formation of feudalism was the characteristic of the medieval society in India. Feudal features listed by historian R.S. Sharma are: royal grants of land; transfer of fiscal and judicial rights to the beneficiaries; the grant of their rights over peasants, artisans and merchants; an increased incidence of forced labour; appropriation of surplus by the state; a decline in trade and coinage; payment of officials through land revenue assignments; and the growth of the obligations of the samantas (subordinate or feudatory rulers).

SUMMARY

- After the Mauryan Empire, the Gupta kingdom emerged as a great power.
- Sri Gupta founded the Gupta dynasty.
- Samudragupta (335–375 CE) conquered and consolidated the empire.
- Chandragupta II through his conquests and matrimonial alliances extended the empire further.
- Kumara Gupta founded the Nalanda University.
- Skanda Gupta repulsed the Huns but Huns' invasion strained his treasury.
- The Gupta kings claimed divine status and were assisted by Council of Ministers and a band of officials.
- The Gupta rulers patronised art, literature and science. Kalidasa, Harisena, Amarasimha, Dhanvantri and Varahamihira adorned their court.
- The drain of treasury because of Huns' invasion and the weak successors of later Guptas led to the decline of the Gupta Empire.

EXERCISE

I. Choose the correct answer

1. Which is the least reliable of the sources for the study of Gupta period?
   (a) Literary sources
   (b) Epigraphical sources
   (c) Numismatic sources
   (d) Myths and legends
2. Choose and match:

Author		Literary Works
(A) Dhanvantri	-	1. SuryaSiddantha
(B) Varahamihira	-	2. Amarakosha
(C) Aryabhatta	-	3. BrihadSamhita
(D) Amarasimha	-	4. Ayurveda

(a) 4, 3, 1, 2 (b) 4, 1, 2, 3
(c) 4, 2, 1, 3 (d) 4, 3, 2, 1

The Guptas 101
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